MIDA MALENA

Maya, Bro & Hakuna Matata

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MAYA, BRO & HAKUNA MATATA / MIDA MALENA
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This book is not intended as a documentary account, nor does it seek to provide a complete, objective, or verifiable record of the journey. Rather, it transforms experience into a story about freedom, intuition, personal boundaries, unexpected encounters, and the way we look at the world — and the way the world looks back at us. The characters are literary constructions and should not be interpreted as exhaustive portrayals of the real people who inspired them. This book is not intended to defame, disparage, or harm the reputation of any person, community, institution, or location.

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This is a sample excerpt from the book “Maya, Bro & Hakuna Matata”
by Mida Malena.
For the full version, visit https://midaway.ro.

Dedicated to all the things that didn't go according to plan.

Fortunately.

1

Maya

I'm at the train station, and I still have no idea which way I'm going.

It would be more worrying if I did. That would mean I had a plan, and plans, as far as I've noticed, have a nasty habit of falling out with reality the exact moment you start relying on them. So I've made myself a much simpler – and therefore much more dangerous – promise: I'll take the first train out.

In front of me, the departures board blinks away, full of numbers, letters, and assorted other symbols it insists on calling information. I stare at it with the patience of someone genuinely trying to understand but apparently lacking some of the necessary organs. It stares back with the same impassive blinking, as though the two of us have been caught in a long-standing administrative misunderstanding.

Somewhere inside me, Bro wakes up at his leisure.

BRO: "You always do this."

I don't hear him with my ears. Bro doesn't need ears, signal, or battery life. He's that part of me that shows up whenever the rest of me starts improvising badly, providing commentary from the sidelines with the kind of clarity I'd normally prefer to have *before* buying tickets.

MAYA: "Do what?"

BRO: "Get to a train station and only then decide where you're going."

MAYA: "You're exaggerating."

BRO: "You have a backpack on your back and no destination."

MAYA: "I have a destination."

BRO: "Where?"

I look at the board again. My eyes drift obediently and uselessly from one line to the next, like employees pretending to work.

MAYA: "I'm looking for it."

The woman at the ticket counter smiles at me before I even reach her. Some people smile at you as though they already know you're about to get confused and, in some inexplicable way, have decided to forgive you in advance.

"Where do you want to go?"

"Kochi?"

I say it like a question, not a destination, but she doesn't seem bothered. Maybe destinations here don't need to be stated with quite so much certainty. Maybe it's enough to suggest them to the world and see if it agrees.

"Sixty rupees. How are you paying?"

"UPI. Wait. What time does it leave?"

She looks at the screen, then at me.

"You're lucky. It's running twenty minutes late. Platform one."

Today, luck in India arrives without fanfare. Not through an open door, not as some grand sign, not in the form of a guru dressed in white pointing me in the right direction, but as a delayed train – delayed by exactly the right amount of time to keep up with a decision made on the spot.

The platform is packed, but trains have their own way of making room for everyone, even when there doesn't seem to be any room left. I weave through the crowd with my backpack on and coffee on my mind. I spot a coffee kiosk before I've even worked out whether I have time to stop.

I do. And if I don't, I'll make some.

Bro is quiet. And when Bro is quiet, it usually doesn't mean he approves. It means he's collecting material for later.

When the train pulls in, I climb into the first carriage that looks willing to have me. I don't know if it's the right one. I don't even know if there is such a thing as a *right carriage* in my story. All around me, doors are open, people are getting on, people are getting off, and I, backpack and all, step into a system I still don't entirely understand but which, for now, seems willing to swallow me without asking too many questions.

I even find a seat. Around me are a few girls, two older men, and a child watching the world with the solemn concentration of a ticket inspector. I put my backpack up on the luggage rack, breathe, and for a few minutes I have the distinct impression that I've beaten the system.

This is, obviously, a temporary impression.

About half an hour later, the ticket inspector appears. A woman in a slightly faded uniform takes my ticket, taps something into her device, then looks up at me. She has that particular administrative calm of someone who already knows you're the problem but is still granting you the privilege of finding out for yourself.

"That'll be another ninety rupees. This is the sleeper coach."

I look at her.

"Uh… seriously? So which coach is my ticket for?"

"The last one. Second class."

"Can I go there?"

"Yes."

"Through the train?"

"Yes."

She delivers that last *yes* with the serenity of someone for whom crossing a moving train with a backpack, through packed carriages, is not an event. It's a minor operation the human species figured out long before I came along with my questions.

I get up with dignity – or as much dignity as you can reasonably maintain after discovering that your actual seat is ten carriages away. I pull my backpack down from the luggage rack, sling it over my shoulder, and set off.

One carriage. Then another. And another.

Indian trains aren't meant to be crossed. They're meant to be accepted.

Between carriages, you negotiate with doors, chains, people, bags, feet, vendors, smells, and your own concept of personal space, which evaporates quickly and without compensation.

Ten carriages. Not fewer.

BRO: "Remember when you said you wanted a quiet day today?"

MAYA: "No."

BRO: "Neither do I."

I reach the last door between carriages and discover that I can't go any farther. The last coach exists, just not for me. Between the two of us there isn't a door, but an architectural decision.

So I stay there, between carriages, until the next station.

It's not actually that bad. Air rushes in around the doors, the train moves beneath my feet, and India streams past me in flashes of green, wet, alive. I take out my phone and start filming. If I can't get where I'm supposed to be, I might as well turn it into a scene.

MAYA: "See? I can handle myself."

BRO: "That wasn't the question."

I wait with my backpack pressed against me, feeling as though the train has just given me a reverse upgrade: from the wrong kind of comfort to the right kind of reality.

When the train slows down, I get off. Not because I want to, but because the last coach – the one my ticket is actually for – can only be reached from the outside.

I can see it down there, at the far end of the railway universe: *second class*. The class of the many. The people who don't ask if there's room. They just get on.

Getting in is a struggle. Men are packed together by the entrance, shoulders, elbows, and knees compressed into the same hot patience. I feel their eyes settle on me – not aggressively, not even necessarily with curiosity, but the way you might look at an unexpected object that has appeared in a place where everything else already has its assigned position.

And now I have to squeeze past them, heavy backpack and all, because there is no other way in.

Inside, the air hangs still and thick, layered with sweat, hot metal, damp clothes, heated plastic, and the smell of food unpacked from containers. It isn't one smell. It's several lives stacked on top of one another.

Every body guards its few inches of space. Every bag seems to have legal rights. Every face says the same thing: there's room for one more, but don't ask how.

BRO: "This is what your ticket was for?"

MAYA: "Officially, yes."

BRO: "Unofficially?"

MAYA: "Unofficially, I think India is testing me."

I push forward with my backpack in front of me, then sideways, then almost on top of someone, trying not to hit knees, heads, bottles, children, or whatever remains of my personal dignity.

A man appears in the aisle carrying a blue barrel, probably filled with ice and drinks. I don't know exactly what he's selling, and it doesn't matter. At that moment, to me, he is the man who can part the carriage.

People move for him.

I fall in behind.

He cuts a path through the carriage; I stay in his wake. Barrels, backpacks, and survival instincts, under certain circumstances, command roughly the same authority. Nobody makes room for a woman who can barely fit through with her backpack, but everybody makes room for a man selling something cold.

About halfway down the carriage, I spot an empty space on the luggage rack above.

Small. Improbable. Almost poetic.

I ask the man with the barrel to help me. He lifts my backpack as though it were a sleeping animal, pushes it up onto the rack, and suddenly my body is no longer carrying my entire biography.

I stay standing between seats and people. There isn't much room, but the windows are wide open, which already feels like luxury.

Five minutes pass. Maybe less. Time in second class isn't measured by a clock. It's measured by how close someone's elbow is to your ribs, by how many stops your body can endure before it stops asking where it's going, and by how many pairs of eyes look you up and down before finally deciding to leave you alone.

A man seated next to me lightly touches my arm and gestures toward his seat.

"I'm getting off at the next stop. You sit here."

I look at him. Then at the seat.

I smile.

BRO: "Don't tell me you got lucky again."

MAYA: "I won't."

BRO: "But you did."

MAYA: "A little."

BRO: "Maya."

MAYA: "Fine. Very."

When the train stops again, the man gets off, and I take his seat with the silent gratitude of someone who has just been handed a palace with a plastic backrest.

I stay there all the way to Kochi, knees tucked in, backpack above my head. Every now and then the train stops. More people get on, others get off. A hand passes in front of me carrying a bag. A child falls asleep with his cheek pressed against his mother's arm. Someone opens up their food. Someone else stares out the window as though the answer to every question might be somewhere out there.

I have no answers. I have a seat in second class, an open window somewhere nearby, and a few hours in which I don't have to decide anything. For now, that's enough.

I get off the train around noon with the vague feeling that I've arrived somewhere, even though my body is still moving to the rhythm of the tracks. The station recedes behind me – all metal, footsteps, voices, and announcements I can't understand – packed with people who seem to know exactly where they're going, which, at this point, strikes me as mildly suspicious.

I know exactly one thing: Fort Kochi.

A small patch on the map.

Maybe.

I remember Bastian Homestay, a place I'd seen online: 1,050 rupees a night. The price seemed reasonable, the place looked clean and almost homely – exactly the kind of illusion a person needs after crossing ten carriages just to reach the class she actually paid for.

BRO: "Did you book it?"

MAYA: "No."

BRO: "Of course not."

MAYA: "I want to see the room first."

BRO: "Big words from someone who didn't know which carriage she belonged in an hour ago."

I roll my eyes internally, because externally I need all available energy just to keep walking in a straight line.

The metro is a few hundred metres from the station. I walk there with my backpack on and the stride of someone who hasn't admitted she's tired yet but has already entered negotiations with the fatigue.

At every crossing, the city seems to size me up: cars, scooters, horns, the smell of warm rain rising from the asphalt, and the occasional dog sprawled with imperial indifference in a spot where I wouldn't dare stand for three seconds.

Taxi drivers ask where I'm going with their eyes.

I keep walking.

I take the metro for two stops. Twenty rupees for a few minutes of air-conditioning and order. The air-conditioning isn't comfort. It's a brief intermission from the reality of the day.

I get off and, for a few seconds, become convinced that things are finally settling into a straight line – which is the first sign that I'm about to misunderstand everything.

I still have a fair bit of the city to cover on foot. Almost two kilometres, according to the map, in its optimistic little voice and complete absence of a backpack.

I set off slowly. Not that I have much choice. The weight pulls at my shoulders, my T-shirt sticks to my back, and within minutes I can feel every single thing inside my backpack as a bad decision made in another lifetime.

I stop once.

Then again.

Not because I can't go on, obviously. I'm admiring the city.

BRO: "You're admiring the kerb."

MAYA: "It's an interesting kerb."

A few drops start to fall. Not real rain, just enough for the sky to remind me that it, too, is participating in the journey.

I take shelter under the edge of a roof beside a tiny shop with narrow shelves and brightly coloured packets hanging by the entrance like flags of everyday survival. The smell of wet dust, hot oil, and overripe fruit mingles in the air.

The city doesn't stop for the rain. It just sweats differently.

Then I reach the jetty, where the boats leave from.

Only then do I realise that Fort Kochi isn't just a neighbourhood you walk into. There is water between me and it. The map, naturally, had not considered this detail dramatic enough to mention. On the screen, everything had looked like a simple line, a reasonable distance, the kind of route a woman with a backpack could manage without beginning to renegotiate her entire life.

I have to get on a boat, pay another forty rupees, and accept that Bastian Homestay, looking so innocent on the map, already requires a combination of transport methods.

The backwaters open up in front of me, wide, murky, alive. There is nothing remarkable about the boat, which is exactly why I like it. Around me are a few students, locals who look as though they've made this crossing a thousand times, a man staring at his phone with absolute concentration, and a woman with her hair pulled tightly back, holding a bag of vegetables against her chest like a well-behaved child.

I sit with my backpack beside me and my eyes on the water. Fort Kochi slowly draws closer: palm trees, old walls, low buildings, and the air of a place that has seen too many ships come and go to remain entirely innocent.

There is something colonial and tired about it, beautiful and slightly weathered, like an old photograph someone forgot in the sun.

BRO: "So you picked the place without knowing you had to cross the water."

MAYA: "I picked it intuitively."

BRO: "Geography weeps."

I get off the boat and check the map. I still have about a kilometre to walk to the homestay.

I haven't booked anything. I want to see the room first, get a feel for the place, find out whether I'll be greeted by a heavy smell or by that particular kind of quiet in which a person can sleep without regretting every decision she has ever made.

And, more importantly, I want coffee.

Actually, by this point, coffee is no longer something I want. It is the only form of navigation I am still willing to accept.

I find a café on the map. Four minutes away.

Four minutes.

A human distance – a small, round promise with milk foam on top.

I cross the jetty and walk out of the little harbour with renewed determination.

BRO: “Coffee?”

MAYA: “Any minute now.”

BRO: “This is serious.”

2

The Woman Who Wanted Coffee

At the port exit, the air changes.

Not much. Just enough for me to realise I've stepped into a place where everyone seems to know something I don't yet.

"Taxi, madam?"

"Tuk-tuk?"

"Where are you going?"

"Island tour?"

"I show you the best places."

They come at me from every direction, their voices overlapping into the local chorus of arrivals. Every port on the planet has its own ritual: men waiting by the exit, watching the luggage, the hesitation, the phones open on Google Maps.

A person with a backpack is never just a person with a backpack.

They're an economic opportunity.

I smile, shake my head, say '*no, thank you*' a few times, and keep walking with the dignity of a woman who knows exactly where she's going.

Which is to a coffee four minutes away.

BRO: "Ambitious itinerary."

MAYA: "Don't ruin this for me."

"Madam, tuk-tuk? Very good tour. Chinese fishing nets, Dutch Palace, synagogue, spice market..."

The tourist list begins, inevitably, delivered with the tired precision of a man who has said the same words a thousand times and still hopes that this time, someone will stop.

Attractions. Landmarks. History.

'Very famous.' 'Very old.' 'Very nice.'

Everything is very something.

"No, no. I'm walking."

I keep going, phone in hand, coffee pinned on the map.

But one of them doesn't leave.

He walks alongside me, sometimes half a step behind, sometimes half a step ahead, in a perfectly choreographed performance of polite persistence. He's stocky, quick, bright-eyed, with a colourful laminated folder in his hand, worn at the corners and full of photographs of places every tourist is apparently required to see before being allowed to leave Fort Kochi.

"Madam, I take you."

"No, I'm walking."

"Where are you going?"

He glances at my phone.

"Ah. Coffee. I take you for coffee."

I stop and laugh.

"It's four minutes away."

He doesn't laugh.

To him, four minutes is plenty of time for a negotiation, a strategy, and, who knows, possibly an entire day.

"No problem. I take you. But first, one shop."

"I don't want to go shopping."

"No shopping. Just looking."

'*Just looking*' is an institution.

It never means just looking.

It means going inside, being seated in a chair, being offered tea, and having silks, gemstones, perfumes, carved wood, shawls, carpets, and, eventually, your own guilt laid out in front of you.

"I'm not buying anything."

"You don't have to buy. I get money."

I look at him.

"What do you mean?"

He starts explaining.

Fast. Very fast. Too fast.

I catch words, lose sentences, cling to meaning the way I clung to the handrails on the train: shop, customer, tuk-tuk, two hundred rupees, you don't buy, no problem, voucher, I get money.

"So I go into the shop…"

"Yes."

"I don't buy anything."

"No need."

"You get money."

"Yes, madam. Two hundred rupees."

"Because I walked in?"

"Yes."

"And then we go for coffee?"

"Yes. Good coffee."

He looks at me with such complete sincerity that, for a few seconds, the whole arrangement starts to resemble a public service.

BRO: "I don't like it when I understand something and still don't like it."

MAYA: "Neither do I."

"No customers today, madam," he says, more quietly now. "No business. You go inside, I get two hundred. You don't buy. Good for me. Good for you. Then coffee."

And that is where something gives way in my defensive logic.

Not completely. Just enough for a tuk-tuk to fit through the crack.

Maybe because I'm tired and hungry and want that coffee with the urgency of a medical intervention. Or maybe because he has that colourful folder in his hand and the small desperation of someone trying to turn an empty day into an acceptable one.

"Fine," I say. "But one shop. Then coffee."

His face lights up instantly.

"Yes, madam! One shop. Then coffee. You wait here. I bring tuk-tuk."

He puts the folder in my hands.

He doesn't just hand it to me. He entrusts it to me – as though it were a relay baton, a child, or physical proof that the two of us have just entered into an agreement neither of us has fully defined.

Then he disappears.

I'm left standing at the port exit with my backpack on, my phone in one hand, and a stranger's colourful folder in the other, as though I've just been temporarily hired by a tour agency without signing anything.

BRO: "Nice."

MAYA: "What?"

BRO: "You wanted coffee. You got responsibilities."

I start laughing to myself. Not loudly, just enough for me to hear it. I've just said yes to a man whose plan I don't fully understand, in a city I arrived in less than an hour ago, all for a coffee that was four minutes away and is somehow becoming increasingly difficult to reach.

The tuk-tuk appears with a small, insolent rattle, like a motorised insect. The man waves at me with his whole arm, delighted.

"Come, madam!"

"What's your name?"

"Safi."

"I'm Maya."

"Maya madam."

"Just Maya."

"Yes, Maya madam."

I climb in. My backpack bangs against the side, I squeeze myself in beside it, and the tuk-tuk jolts off through Fort Kochi, away from my café – the one that was supposed to be four minutes away.

Only then do I begin to understand the arrangement.

Safi takes tourists to certain shops. The shops give him a voucher, proof that he has successfully delivered a foreign body through their doors, and then he gets his commission. Two hundred rupees for a customer brought in by tuk-tuk. Four hundred for one brought by car.

It doesn't matter whether the tourist buys anything. What matters is that they go inside, look around, and are exposed to the beauty.

The rest is commercial hope.

The first shop doesn't look like a shop. It looks like a museum that, for reasons open to question, accepts credit cards.

I walk in, backpack and all, slightly sweaty, slightly confused, still dreaming about coffee. An impeccably dressed man smiles at me from behind a wall of professional composure.

"Welcome, madam. Please, come in."

It's cool inside. Or maybe there's just a lot of shade. After the street, any amount of shade feels like a form of luxury. I leave my backpack on a chair and immediately feel twenty kilos more elegant.

All around me unfolds a world of objects that seem to have waited hundreds of years for the sole purpose of demonstrating that I can't afford any of them: antiques, silks, carved figurines, wooden boxes with tiny locks, stones that catch the light and hold it captive, perfumes in little bottles, soft shawls, carpets hanging from the walls, rolled up, spread out, all of them promising homes, floors, and lives I do not have.

I realise very quickly that everything here is partly a museum. Even the shops seem designed for people who walk in with their hands clasped behind their backs and walk out with mortgages.

The salesman shows me a silk scarf.

"Pure silk, madam. Very good quality."

He touches it lightly, unfurls it into the air, and the fabric spills across the light like coloured water.

It's beautiful.

Of course it's beautiful.

That's the trouble with beautiful things: it isn't their fault they don't fit into your life.

"How much is it?"

"Four thousand rupees."

I smile with all the aristocracy I can muster.

"It's very beautiful."

In the universal language of the broke tourist, *it's very beautiful* means *no*.

The salesman keeps trying. He shows me another one. Then another. Colours, textures, promises.

For a few minutes, I play the part of a woman who could buy anything in the shop but simply hasn't made up her mind yet for aesthetic reasons rather than financial ones.

It's a pleasant role. Brief, but pleasant.

Then I see the carpet.

I don't know how to describe it without sounding ridiculous. It's the kind of carpet that requires more than money. It requires a destiny. A large house. A quiet living room. Tall windows. A life in which nobody ever walks inside wearing shoes, not even by accident.

I stand in front of it and, for a second, imagine the house.

Not my house, because my entire house is currently sitting inside a backpack on a chair.

A possible house. One belonging to a version of me who knows how to buy carpets without mentally checking the exchange rate first.

"Very special, madam," the salesman says.

"Yes. I can see that."

"Handmade."

Of course it's handmade.

No ten-thousand-euro carpet should be allowed to be anything else.

"How much?"

He tells me the price.

I laugh a little. Elegantly. I don't want to offend the carpet.

"When I buy a house, I'll come back for it."

The salesman smiles.

"I give you very good discount."

"Perfect. But let's make sure the house costs a little more than the carpet, okay?"

I'm not sure he gets the joke, but he keeps smiling, which, in retail, is a form of patience.

I walk out with no scarf, no stones, no perfume, no carpet. Just my eyes full of everything.

Safi is waiting for me outside.

He doesn't ask whether I bought anything. I like that about him. He doesn't look like a man who'd made a serious investment in me. He just has the satisfaction of someone who has already got what he needed.

He holds up the little voucher between two fingers.

"Two hundred rupees, Maya madam!"

He's happy.

Purely, genuinely happy.

As though I haven't just refused to buy a scarf, but the two of us have won a match together.

BRO: "Congratulations. You went shopping without shopping."

MAYA: "And made money without buying anything."

BRO: "Minimalist capitalism."

Safi heads towards the tuk-tuk with the energy of a man whose day has just got back on its feet.

"One more shop? Then coffee. Now we have money for coffee."

I look at him, then at the street, and think about my coffee, which is drifting farther and farther away like a promise with flexible opening hours.

And then I laugh.

"Come on, Safi. One more."

You can't imagine how happy he is.

Or maybe you can, if you've ever seen someone accidentally handed exactly the little piece of luck they needed not to go home with an empty day.

The tuk-tuk sets off again.

I sit in the back with my backpack beside me, my hair sticking to the back of my neck, the colourful folder on my knees, and the distinct feeling that I've somehow joined a tour no travel agency has ever invented: the tour of sublime objects you do not buy.

Guide: Safi.

Price: zero rupees for me.

Profit: two hundred rupees per stop for him.

Coffee: still uncertain.

The day, which began with a delayed train and was supposed to continue with a simple cup of coffee, has just changed species entirely.

At the second shop, Safi pulls the tuk-tuk up outside and turns to me with a new kind of authority, the authority of a man who feels our relationship has already survived its first commercial test.

"Leave your bag here. Don't carry it. I won't run away."

By now, he has given me his WhatsApp number, which, by the logic of the day, already seems like a sufficient social contract.

"I have your number, Safi. I'm not worried you'll run away."

He laughs, delighted, as though I've just paid him a serious compliment.

"Good, Maya madam. Go. Just looking."

I go in without my backpack and immediately feel lighter, almost fraudulent, as though what I've left outside isn't a piece of luggage but the evidence of my real life.

Inside, another salesman greets me. Thinner than the first, smoother in his movements, with a smile already prepared for every possible form of refusal.

"Please, madam. Tea?"

"No, thank you."

"Earrings?"

"No, thank you."

"Silk scarf?"

"No, thank you."

"Just see."

Just see returns, naturally, as the standard formula of every shop you enter as a free human being and leave as a survivor of commercial politeness.

He shows me earrings, brings out scarves, opens drawers, boxes, little pouches – tiny worlds of metal, stone, and silk.

Every object comes with a story. Every story comes with a price. Every price comes with a pause in which I'm apparently supposed to feel guilty.

I smile, admire, touch, and say *beautiful* with almost diplomatic delicacy, but I hold my ground.

In the end, I thank him for his kindness with the solemnity of a woman who has just crossed a battlefield of silk and silver without losing a single rupee.

I step back out onto the street, and Safi is waiting beside the tuk-tuk, his face lit up.

He has the voucher in his hand.

"Two hundred!"

He holds it up slightly, like good news.

And it is good news.

BRO: "Careful. You're starting to root for the scheme."

MAYA: "I'm not rooting for the scheme."

BRO: "You're rooting for its accountant."

"Coffee now?" I ask.

"Yes, yes. Coffee."

Naturally, we do not go for coffee.

We go to a little local eatery instead.